

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

EMPTY GROUNDS
Students hostel area in Coral Park

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RAJESH JAIN
Founder-president, Property Dealers' Association, Kota

growth plans in Kota. More than 80 per cent of the 25,000 rooms are vacant, with some investors defaulting on bank loans. Rajesh Jain, founder-president, Property Dealers' Association, Kota, and owner of Mangalam Properties, says: "Hostels in Coral Park that cost Rs 6 crore now have no buyers even for Rs 2.5 crore. I put Rs 3.5 crore two and a half years ago in a hostel for 60 students. I barely get 4-5 students."

Meanwhile, teacher salaries are reportedly being slashed. Discontented faculty are setting up their own low-cost academies like Sarvam and Careerwill, charging as little as Rs 60,000 annually, compared to the Rs 1 lakh charged by their more prominent peers.

DEATH BY SUICIDE

Kota's reputation has also been stained by the tragedy of students ending their lives because of curricular pressure or parental expectations. Many of the aspirants who come to the city hail from middle-class or even low-income backgrounds, with their families often taking loans or mortgaging property to fund the coaching of their wards. And whereas coaching institutes initially screened applicants and admitted only the capable ones, as competition grew, they became lax about the eligibility criteria. Many students found it difficult to cope with the extensive curriculum, and languished as coaching institutes increasingly concentrated on students who were more likely to crack the JEE and bring them credit.

In just the first 22 days of January 2025, six students died by suicide. The police, with assistance from Meta and the K-SOS app, have tracked distressed students and reportedly averted 29 suicides this year. However, as SP Amrita Duhan says, "There isn't a single suicide where coaching centres are directly to blame. The reasons include academic stress, love affairs, drug abuse and unrealistic expectations." The police have arrested suppliers of contraband, increased patrolling near coaching hubs, and addressed 314 helpline complaints this year. But it still has not saved Kota from the tag of 'Suicide City', never mind that it is not even among the top 40 cities in student suicides proportionate to population. "No other city's suicide cases make national headlines the way Kota's do," says Ravindra Goswami, the former collector of Kota.

Faced with a growing crisis, coaching giants like Allen have set up 24x7 counselling centres like Sahyog. "Misinformation about suicides has certainly hurt us," says Maheshwari. But he also believes coaching centres are being unfairly targeted, especially the provisional regulations of the Union education ministry which ban residential coaching for students under 16. "Either you improve the education system so that we are not required. Else allow us to fill the gap that helps students from every walk of life," he says. Change is necessary, both in public policy and the way coaching centres run their business. Until then, Kota will remain in coaching purgatory. ■